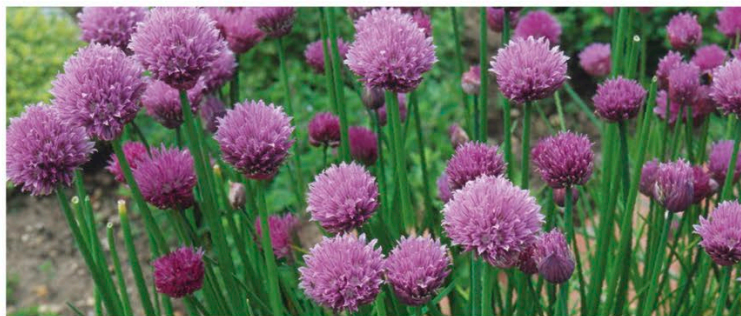




Plants for productive patios

You'll struggle to create a productive patio in deep shade, but partial shade affords the cool growing conditions preferred by a number of leafy crops.

Lettuce, Swiss chard, arugula, herbs such as mint and parsley, and other leafy crops thrive in light shade. Fruit crops that ripen in light or dappled shade include blackberries, alpine strawberries, currants, and some apple varieties, so although the choice is not extensive, there are still plenty of options for a healthy harvest. Plant fruit trees and shrubs in large tubs of soil-based potting mix and replace the top layer with fresh potting mix with added all-purpose granular fertilizer each spring. Apart from peas and beans, which need big containers, vegetables and herbs will be happy in medium-sized containers of potting mix.



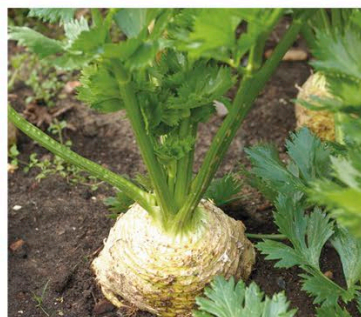
BULB MEDIUM

Chives

Allium schoenoprasum This herb forms a clump of upright, slender green leaves that have a mild onionlike flavor. Its fluffy pale pink pom-pom summer flowers can also be cropped. Plant it in windowboxes and containers of potting mix.

↑30cm (12in)

☹ Z4–8

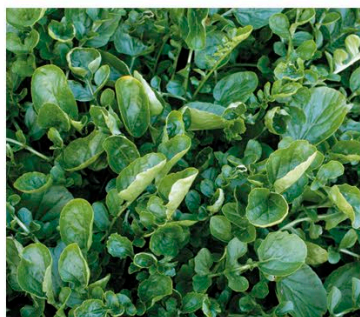


ANNUAL/BIENNIAL MEDIUM

Celeriac

Apium graveolens This crop is grown for its swollen roots that have a mild nutty celerylike flavor. Sow seeds in spring, and harvest baby roots in summer or mature crops in fall. In zones 7 and higher, plant in summer for a fall, winter, or spring crop.

↑3ft (1m) ↔18in (45cm)



ANNUAL/BIENNIAL SMALL

Land cress

Barbarea verna A low-growing annual, this alternative to watercress has pepper-flavored leaves. Sow seeds in windowboxes and pots in spring and summer; harvest the leaves and stems when large enough. Re-sow regularly; water and feed well.

↑↑12in (30cm)



ANNUAL/BIENNIAL SMALL

Swiss chard

Beta vulgaris This crop is grown for its leaves, which can be eaten raw or steamed, and its fleshy stems that are best cooked. Sow seeds in spring and harvest in summer. Ideal for containers and windowboxes; water regularly.

↑↑18in (45cm)

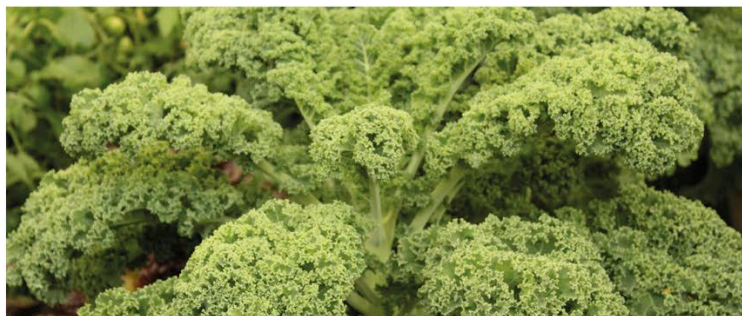


ANNUAL/BIENNIAL SMALL

Mustard greens

Brassica juncea Grown for its peppery leaves, which can be repeat-harvested when young or left to mature. Sow seeds in spring and summer. Grow in containers and windowboxes in light shade. Water well. Considered invasive in many areas.

↑↑12in (30cm)



ANNUAL/BIENNIAL SMALL

Kale

Brassica oleracea Acephala Group This upright leafy crop is planted in summer and can be harvested from fall to winter. When grown in containers, it is best picked as individual leaves when required. Water well and stake if required.

↑↑18in (45cm)



ANNUAL/BIENNIAL SMALL

Mizuna

Brassica rapa subsp. nipposinica var. laciniata Sown from seed from spring to summer, this leaf crop has a peppery flavor. Harvest after a few weeks as a "cut-and-come-again" salad or cut whole plants at the base. Considered invasive in many areas.

↑↑6in (15cm)

